JULY 24, 2026 · PHILADELPHIA

The Biggest Heist in NBA Free Agency History

What LeBron James to the 76ers actually means — every number derived from source data.

Verified play-by-play stats, a from-scratch playoff-probability model, and measured history of what happens to teammates when LeBron arrives.

THE DEAL

A four-MVP resume at 2.35% of the salary cap

2 yrs · $8M	**$3,876,529**	**-92%**	**2.35%**
player option on 2027-28 ($4.07M)	2026-27 cap hit — the 10+ yr veteran minimum	pay cut from his $52.6M Lakers salary, the largest in NBA history	of the $164.96M cap for the all-time scoring leader (43,440 pts)

“This is my last decision. I’m not going for money. I’m not going for family… I still want to compete, to win and to have a chance at the feeling of winning another championship.”

— LeBron James, announcing on X, entering season 24 at age 41 (42 on Dec 30)

The new starting five

Maxey · Edgecombe · Brown · James · Embiid

36 All-Star selections and 5 MVP awards combined. Brown arrived July 2 from Boston for Paul George and four picks; LeBron arrived for the minimum.

Contract: Klutch to ESPN; cap figures NBA.com (2026-27 cap $164.961M). Salary history: Fortune. Roster: CBS Sports, NBC News.

WHY PHILADELPHIA

The one fatal flaw — nobody creates easy shots — is the thing he fixes

The 2025-26 Sixers won 45 games while being outscored (SRS –0.27) — a 7-seed that survived on Maxey's solo shot-making and lost the moment the playoffs demanded easy offense (swept 4-0 by the champion Knicks).

LeBron is the most decorated table-setter alive: 9 of 10 seasons from 2008-09 to 2017-18 his offenses finished top-5 as he ran them solo. In 2025-26, 42.1% of his assists produced rim shots and 11.8% corner threes — the two most efficient shots in basketball. His 162 corner-3 assists in 2016-17 remain the most ever recorded.

55.3% of Maxey's 694 makes were unassisted — league mean is 36.3%

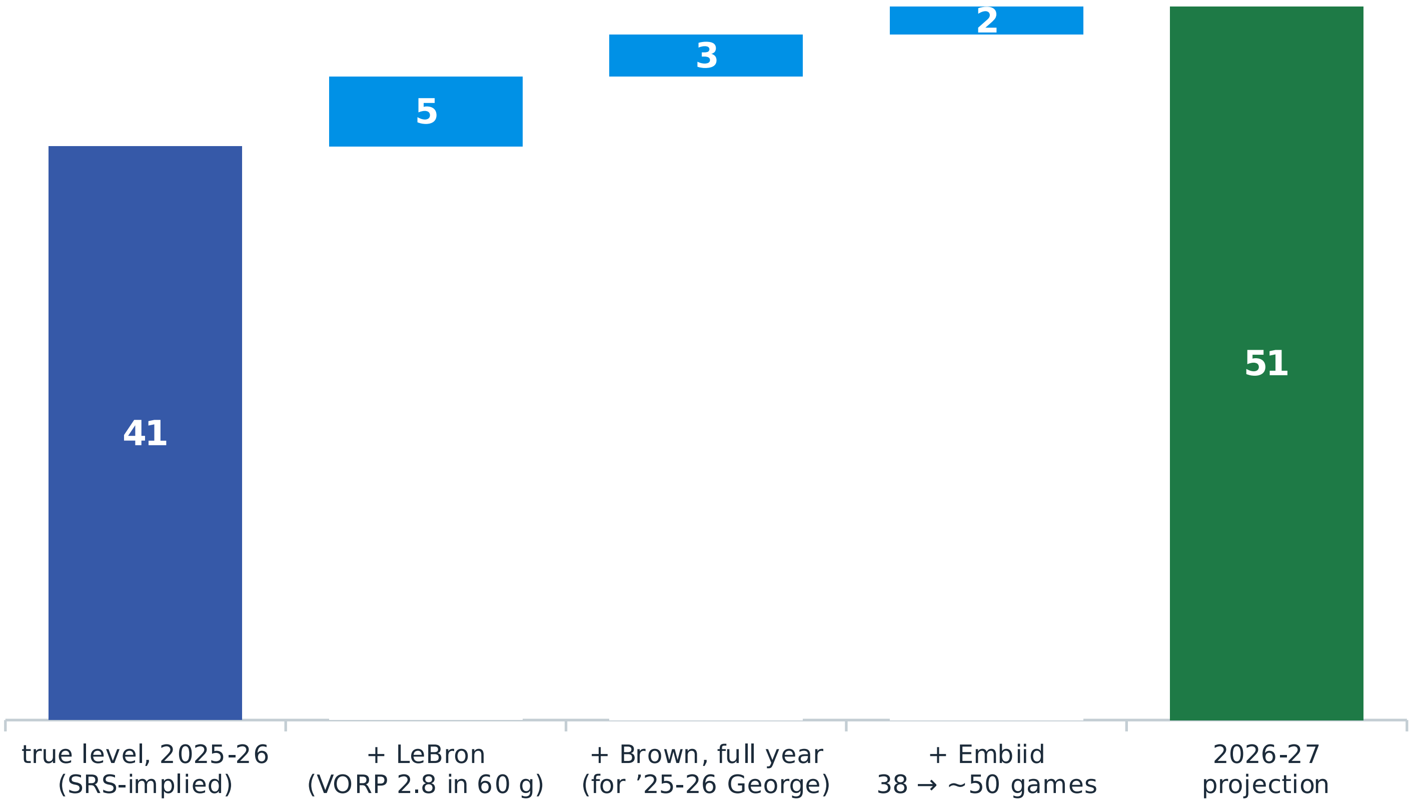
34.9% of Embiid's makes came at the rim — an MVP big living on jumpers

36.4% of Brown's makes were assisted carrying Boston — down from 47.6%

5.5% of rookie Edgecombe's makes were corner 3s — the skip pass never came

All shot-profile splits: pbpstats.com play-by-play totals, cross-checked vs Basketball-Reference; identical to the decimal. Offense ranks: pbpstats ORtg (±1 on borderline years).

45 wins was a mirage; 51 is the honest projection



The ledger

45-37 overstated the 2025-26 team: its –0.27 point differential is 41-win talent. LeBron’s 2025-26 value (B-Ref VORP 2.8 in 60 games ≈ 7.6 wins over replacement) nets ~+5 over the minutes he displaces; a full year of Jaylen Brown replacing 36-year-old Paul George nets ~+3; Embiid reaching ~50 games adds ~+2.

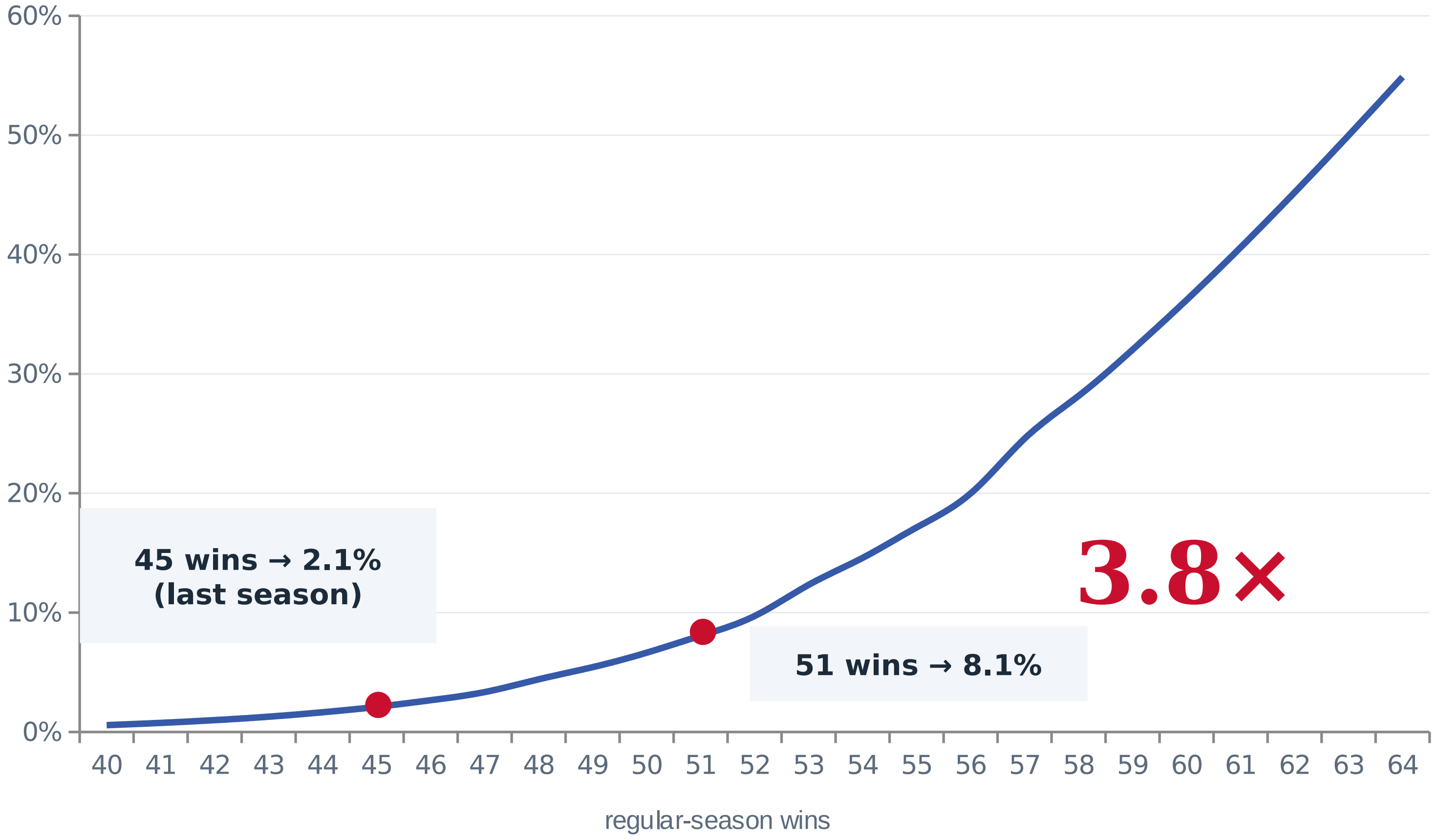
The market agrees

FanDuel set the post-signing win total at 50.5. Title odds moved +2000 → +900 (DraftKings) within hours. Two independent routes, one answer.

SRS & VORP: Basketball-Reference. Win total & odds: FanDuel via Liberty Ballers; DraftKings via NBC Sports. VORP→wins ×2.7 conversion is standard.

THE CURVE THAT MAKES IT A HEIST

Finals probability is logistic — six wins land on the steep part



The model: Log5 game odds + home court, exact best-of-7, three rounds vs a 48/53/57-win playoff gauntlet. 45 wins → 2.1%; 51 → 8.1% (3.8×); 52 → 9.7% (4.6×).

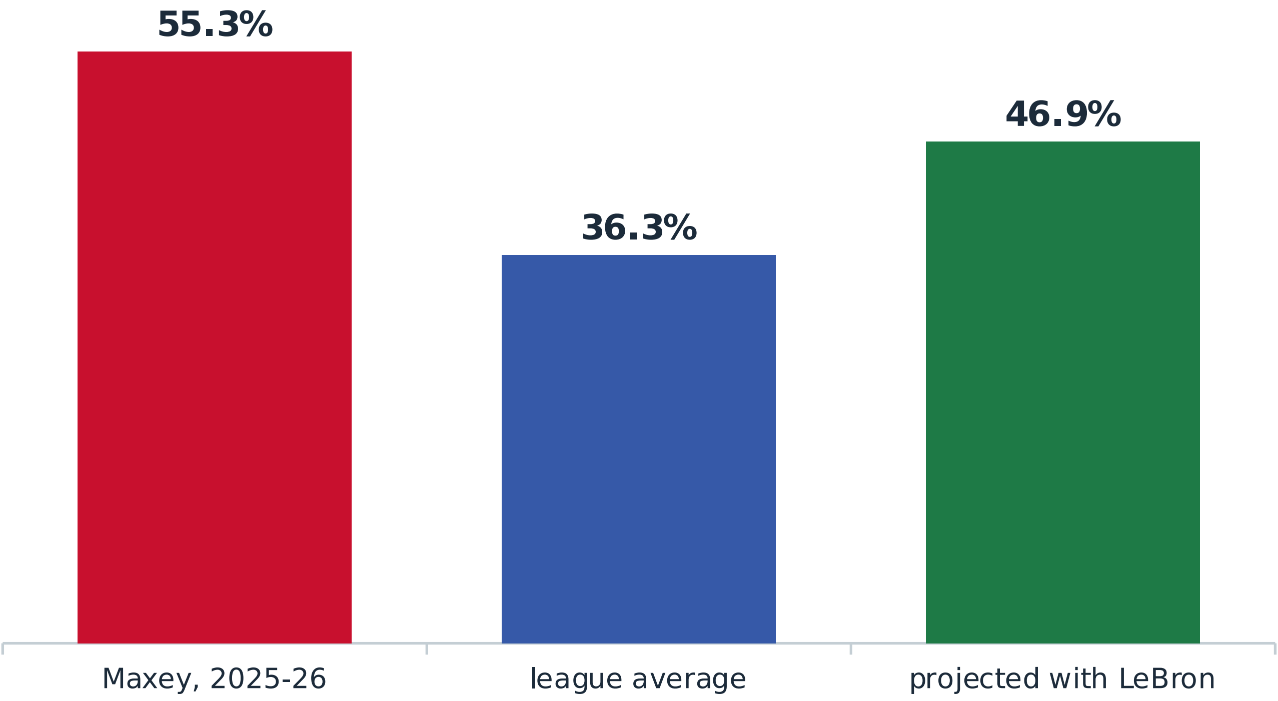
History says the same: since 1984, 44-47-win teams took 2 of 78 full-season Finals berths (2.6%) — and no 7-seed has ever made the Finals. The median finalist won 58. 50+ wins covered 96% of all berths.

The point: the six wins LeBron adds sit exactly where the curve bends.

Model: model.py in this repo (Log5, HCA odds ×1.21, 2-2-1-1-1). Empirics: 86 Finals berths 1984-2026, Wikipedia champions list + season standings.

Maxey — five years of doing it alone

Unassisted share of made field goals, 2025-26 (694 FGM)



55.3% of Maxey’s baskets were self-created — 19 points above the league mean. He led the team at 28.3 ppg on 70 games of isolation offense.

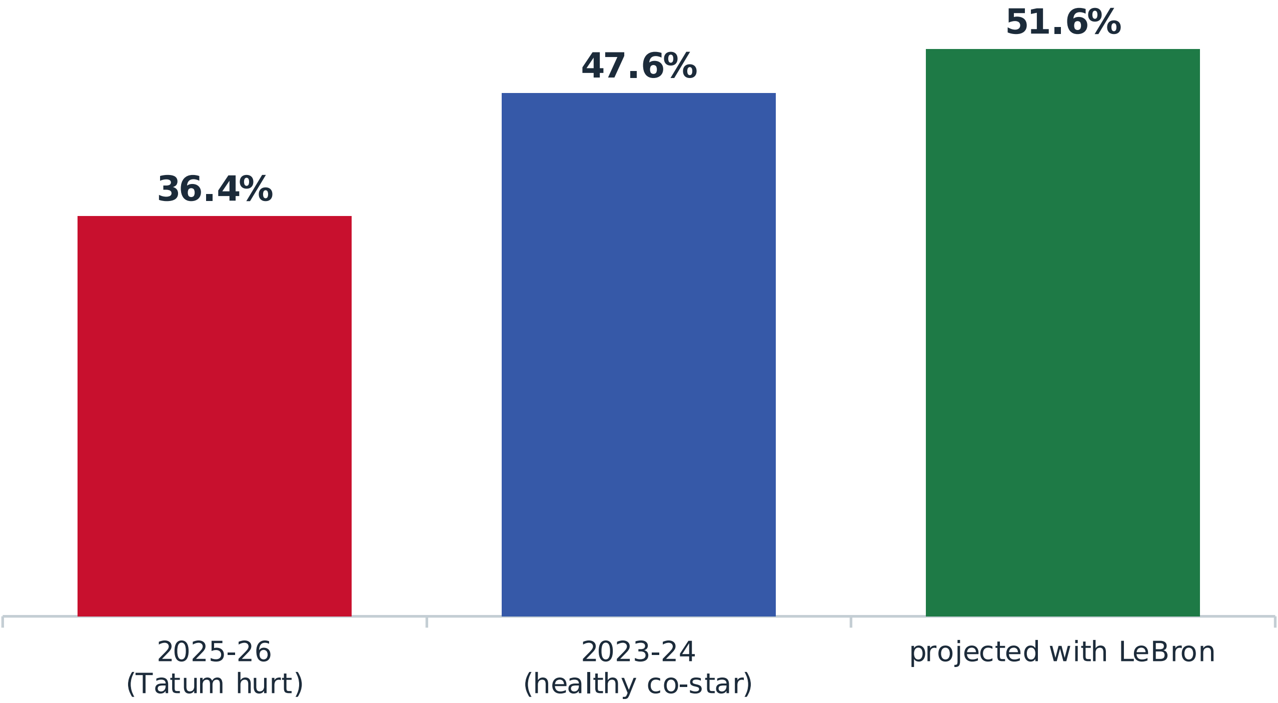
The projection: guards who joined LeBron saw their assisted share rise +8.4 pts on average (Mo Williams +12.6, D’Angelo Russell +11.1, Kyrie +1.5 — and Kyrie’s 3P assisted share jumped 45.5→61.8%). Applied to Maxey: unassisted falls to ~47%.

For the first time in his career, he gets to run to a spot and shoot.

Splits: pbpstats/B-Ref (2P 37.8% astd, 3P 59.5% astd). Comps: first-season-with-LeBron deltas, pbpstats 2000-01+.

Brown — a Finals MVP getting easy ones again

Assisted share of made field goals (736 FGM in 2025-26)



Carrying Boston at a career-high 36.2% usage, Brown’s assisted share collapsed to 36.4%. With a healthy star beside him in 2023-24 it was 47.6%.

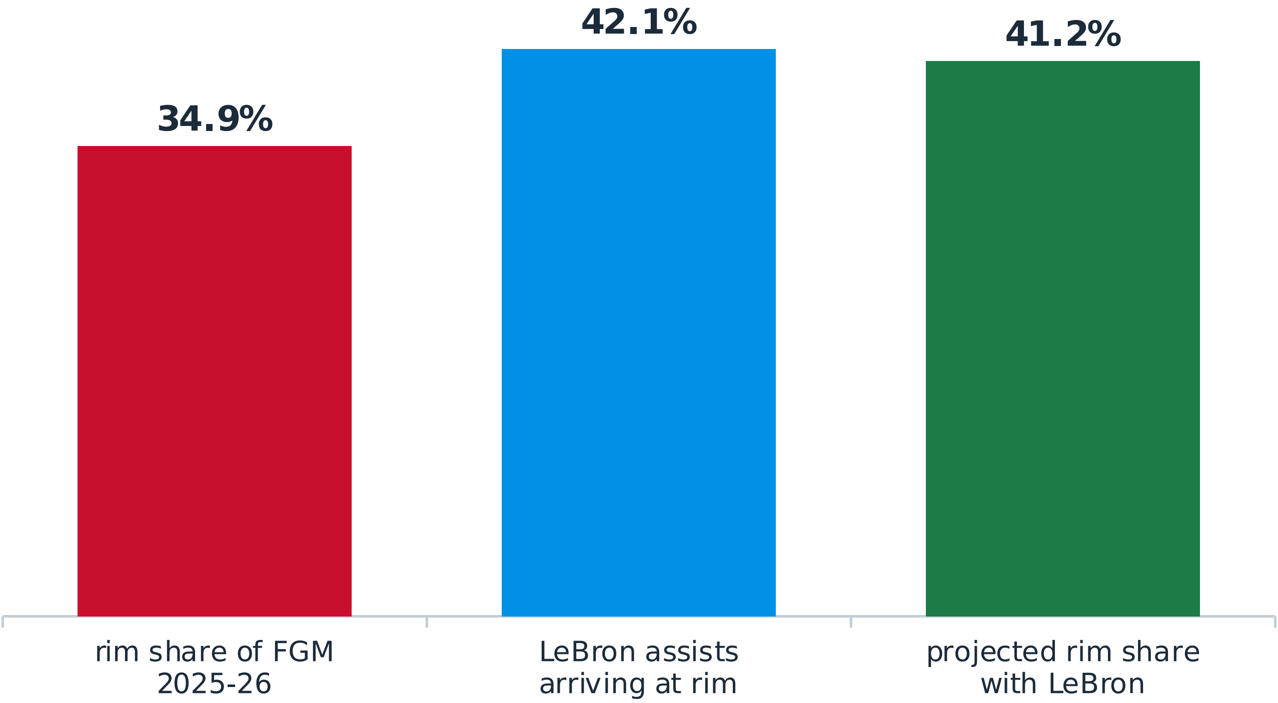
The projection: restore the healthy-co-star baseline, then add half the average LeBron-arrival premium (+4.0): ~52% assisted. LeBron delivers the ball early in the clock, not with three seconds left.

The easiest shot diet of his career, at age 30.

Splits: pbpstats/B-Ref both seasons (25-26: 2P 32.4% astd, 3P 53.6% astd; 23-24: 42.9%/63.4%).

Embiid — an MVP big fed where he wants it

At-rim share of made field goals (341 FGM in 38 games)



Only 34.9% of Embiid’s makes came at the rim — a skilled giant surviving on fadeaways because nobody could get him the ball where he wanted it.

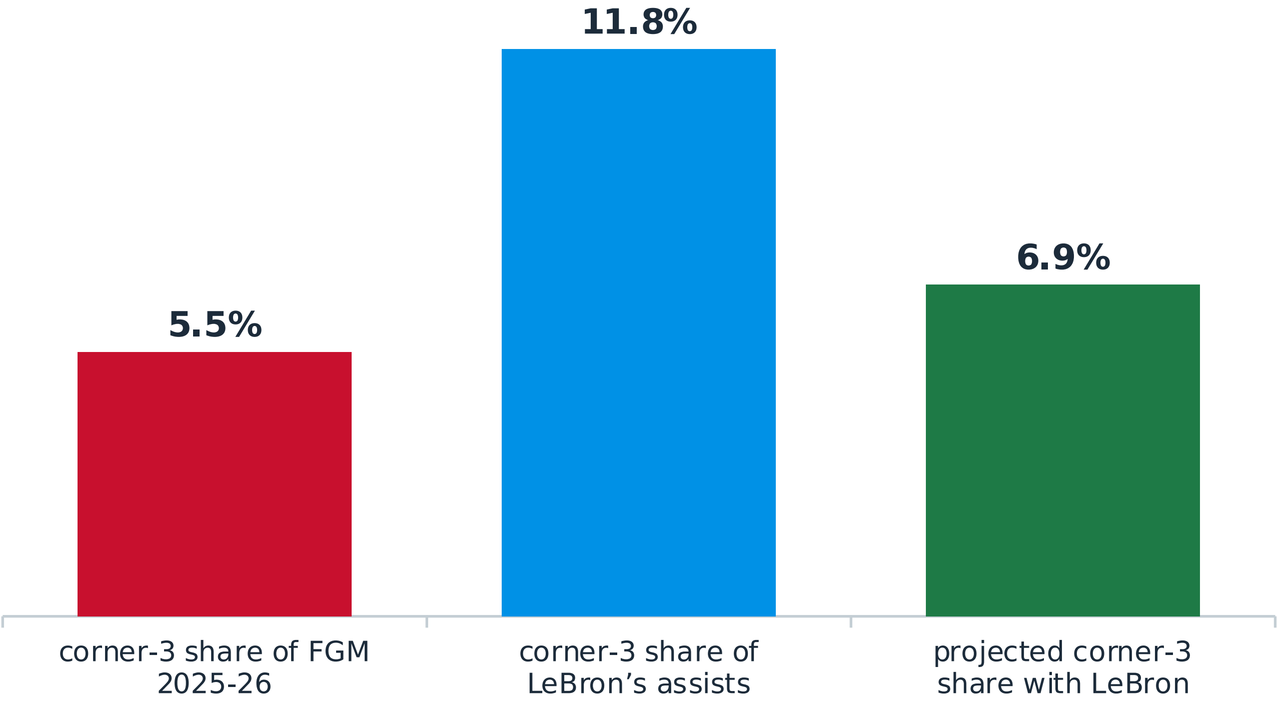
The projection: 42.1% of LeBron’s 432 assists arrived at the rim (46.6% the year before) — the pocket pass, the lob, the entry nobody else sees. If LeBron assists ~25% of Embiid’s makes at a big-man rim rate (~60%), Embiid’s rim share climbs to ~41% (range 39-44).

Bosh and Love both saw double-digit jumps in assisted makes the year LeBron arrived. Embiid is a better interior finisher than either.

Rim = pbpstats ‘at rim’ (119/341). LeBron assist locations: pbpstats 2025-26 (182 rim / 51 corner-3 / 93 AB3 / 106 midrange).

Edgecombe — the skip pass finally comes

Corner-3 share of made field goals (451 FGM as a rookie)



25 of Edgecombe's 451 makes (5.5%) were corner threes — even though 81% of his 3-point makes were assisted. The cross-court skip simply never came from this roster.

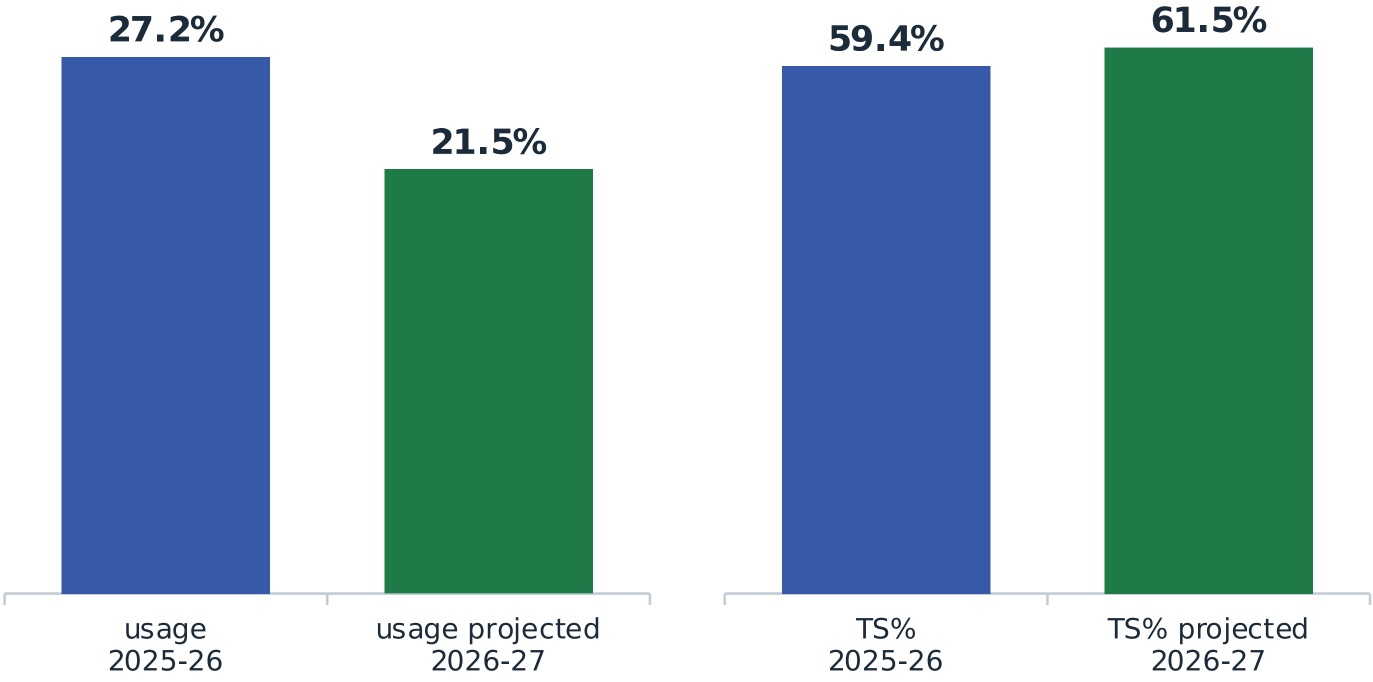
The projection: LeBron throws the skip better than anyone alive — 11.8% of his assists were corner 3s, and his 162 corner-3 assists in 2016-17 are the most ever recorded. If LeBron assists ~22% of Edgecombe's makes: ~7% (range 6.5-7.4).

A ~30% relative jump in the most efficient catch-and-shoot look in basketball — free points that were just sitting there.

Corner-3 counts: pbpstats (25 makes / 67 attempts). B-Ref's different corner-zone definition gives ~20 makes.

LeBron — fewer possessions, the perfect ones

Usage rate and true shooting, 2025-26 measured → 2026-27 projected



Usage: 27.2% was already a career low (his rookie floor was 28.2%). Stars who joined LeBron shed 5-7 usage points (Bosh 28.5→23.4, Love 28.7→21.6). Now he's the one joining three stars: ~21-22%, the fewest possessions of his life.

Efficiency: the skill-curve tradeoff (+0.3-0.6 TS pts per usage point shed, minus an age-42 drag) projects .594 → .60-.63 — brushing career-best territory (.649 in 2013-14) at the top of the band.

At 42, in a Sixers jersey, plausibly the most efficient season of his life.

Usage/TS: B-Ref & StatMuse (27.2 B-Ref method; NBA.com's formula says 26.2 — both career lows). Sheds: StatMuse. Skill curve: usage-efficiency tradeoff literature.

THE HEIST, QUANTIFIED

18 cents on the dollar

$21.9M

modeled market value of his 2026-27 production (Sporting News salary model via CBS; $28.2M for 2025-26)

$3.88M

what Philadelphia pays. Surplus ≈ $18M — about 5 wins of talent, free

3.8×

the Finals-odds multiplier those six extra wins buy on the logistic curve

207×

StubHub demand spike within hours; debut get-in $107 → $540; jerseys gone in ~2 hours

Cross-check: ~5 wins added × ~$3.9M market price per win ≈ $20M. Three methods, one answer: the Sixers acquired a top-25 player for the price of a 12th man.

METHOD & SOURCES

Every number, re-derived

Data

Shot profiles & assist locations: pbpstats.com play-by-play API, cross-checked against Basketball-Reference splits (agreement to the decimal) and StatMuse.

Standings, SRS, advanced value: Basketball-Reference 2025-26.

Contract & cap: NBA.com, ESPN/Klutch, CBS Sports. Market: FanDuel/DraftKings via NBC & Liberty Ballers; StubHub/SeatGeek via 6abc.

Models (in this repo)

Finals curve: Log5 game probabilities, home-court odds ×1.21, exact best-of-7 enumeration, three rounds vs a 48/53/57 gauntlet (model.py).

Win ledger: SRS-implied baseline + VORP-based wins added (final_calcs.py).

Teammate projections: first-season-with-LeBron deltas measured for 6 stars, 2000-2026 (projections.py).

Honesty box

Projections carry ranges, not certainties; central values shown.

Stat sites draw shot zones differently (corner-3, at-rim); pbpstats' exact play-by-play counts are used, with alternates noted in slide footers.

Embiid availability (38 games) is the single biggest swing factor no model fixes.

Compiled July 25, 2026 — the day after the signing.